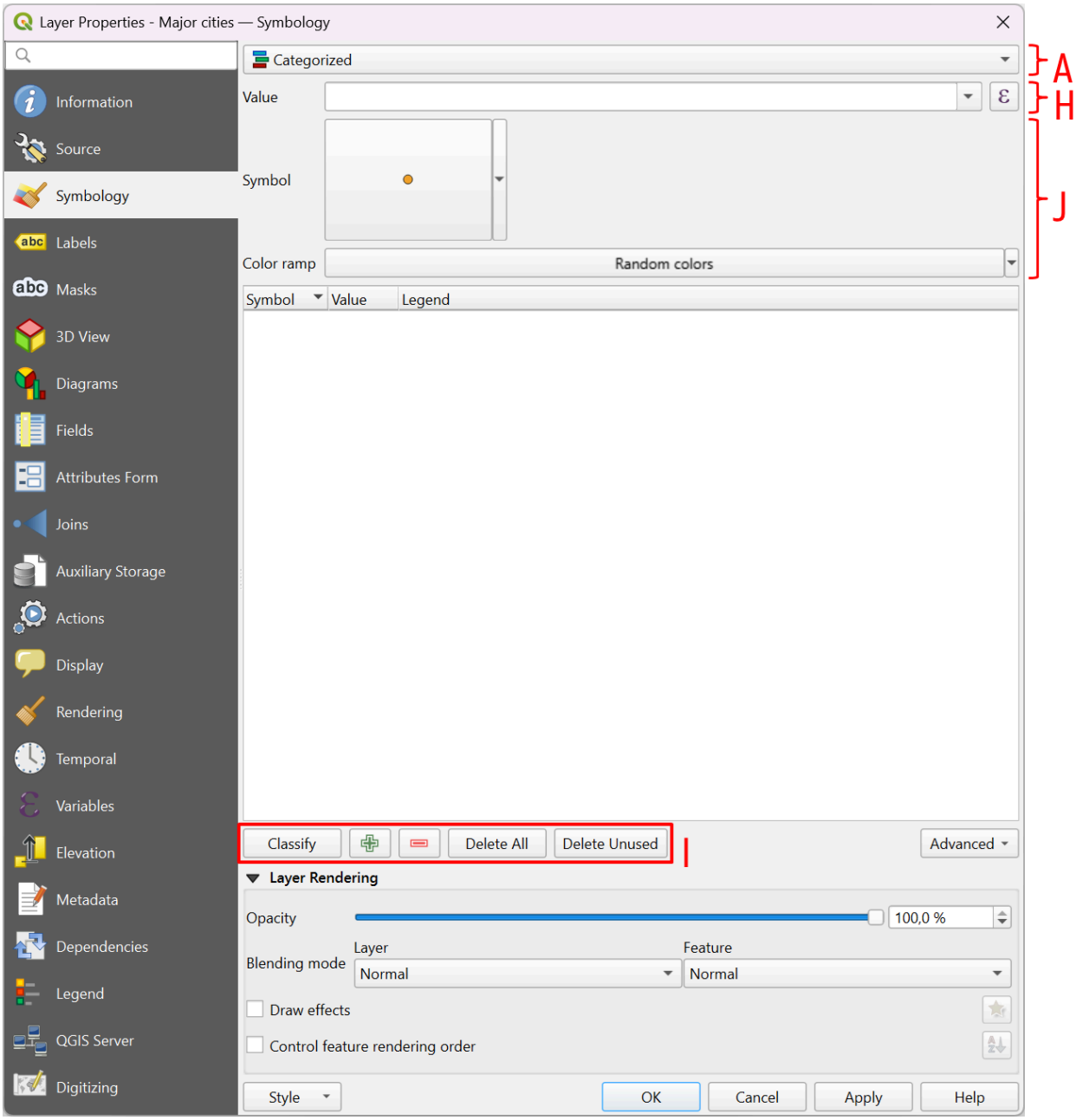
4.2.4 One style per category

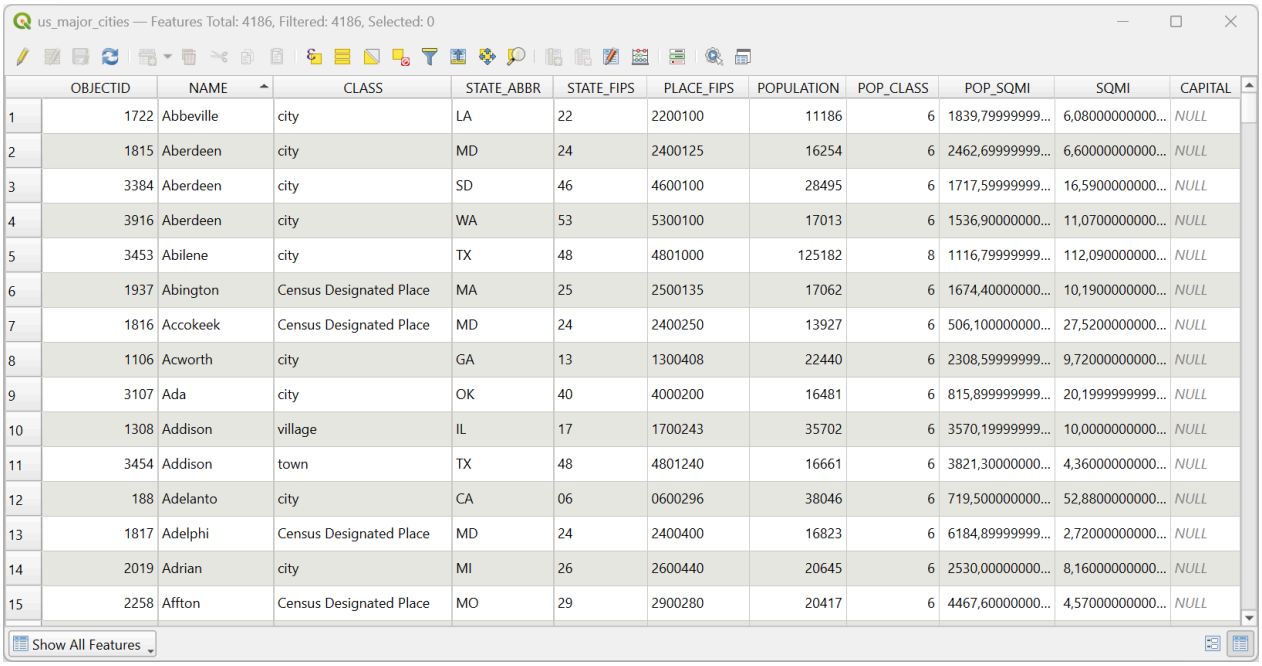
On the previous page all features of a layer got the same symbol (*Single Symbol*). Sometimes, however, you want to **differentiate visually between the features of one layer** based on a certain characteristic: for example, show the places in the United States in a different colour depending on their class (*city*, *town*, *village*...).

To do this, choose ***Categorized*** in the drop-down list at the top of the *Symbology* tab (A). With *Categorized*, every value of an attribute field gets its own symbol.



Under *Value* (H) you choose the attribute field on which you want to base the categories. The drop-down list shows all fields of the layer: the columns of its **attribute table**. The attribute table of the places

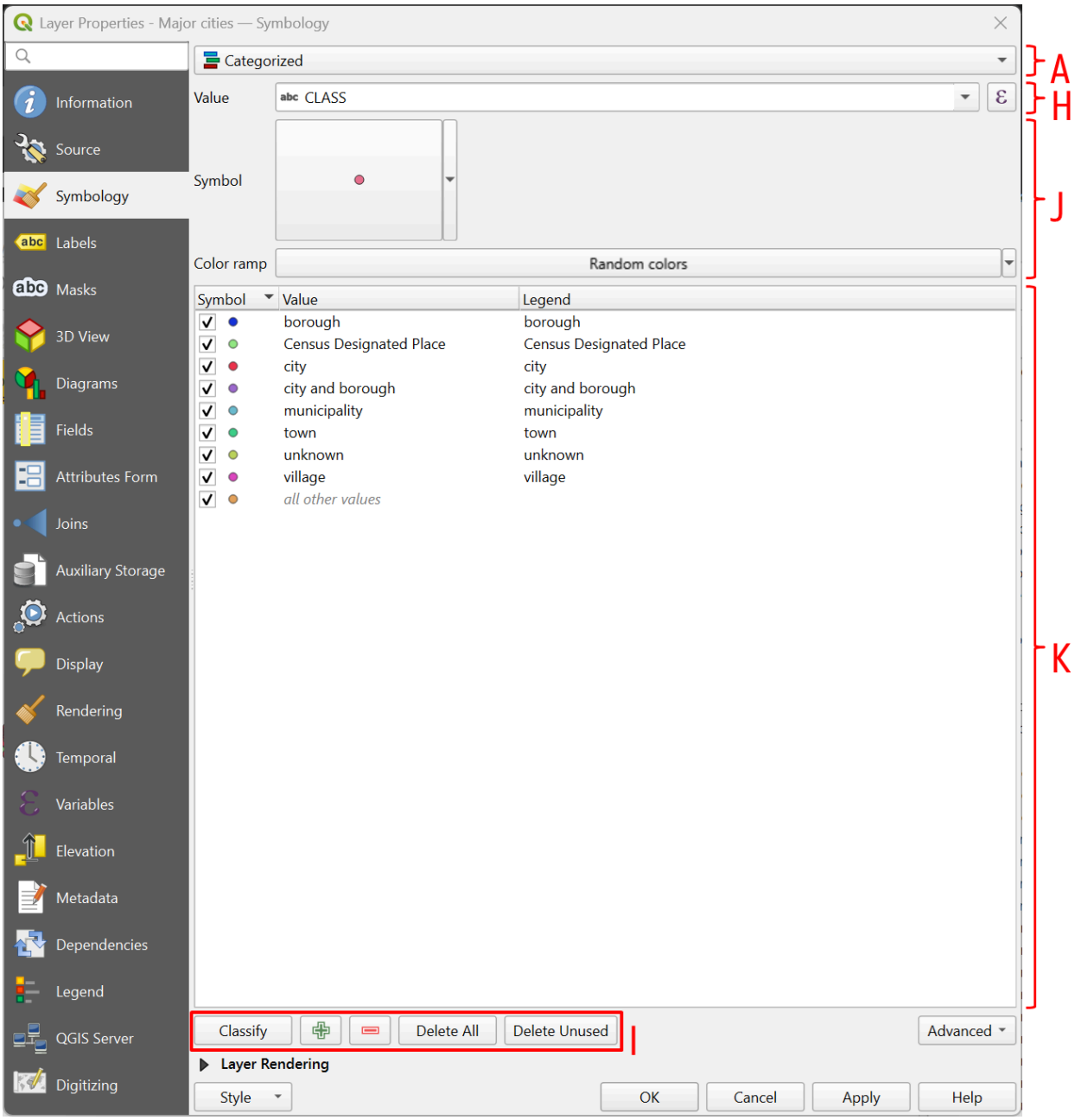
below, for example, contains for each place its name (`NAME`), its class (`CLASS`) and its number of inhabitants (`POPULATION`). In our example we categorise on `CLASS`.



	OBJECTID	NAME	CLASS	STATE_ABBR	STATE_FIPS	PLACE_FIPS	POPULATION	POP_CLASS	POP_SQMI	SQMI	CAPITAL
1	1722	Abbeville	city	LA	22	2200100	11186	6	1839,79999999...	6,08000000000...	NULL
2	1815	Aberdeen	city	MD	24	2400125	16254	6	2462,69999999...	6,60000000000...	NULL
3	3384	Aberdeen	city	SD	46	4600100	28495	6	1717,59999999...	16,5900000000...	NULL
4	3916	Aberdeen	city	WA	53	5300100	17013	6	1536,90000000...	11,0700000000...	NULL
5	3453	Abilene	city	TX	48	4801000	125182	8	1116,79999999...	112,090000000...	NULL
6	1937	Abington	Census Designated Place	MA	25	2500135	17062	6	1674,40000000...	10,1900000000...	NULL
7	1816	Accokeek	Census Designated Place	MD	24	2400250	13927	6	506,100000000...	27,5200000000...	NULL
8	1106	Acworth	city	GA	13	1300408	22440	6	2308,59999999...	9,72000000000...	NULL
9	3107	Ada	city	OK	40	4000200	16481	6	815,899999999...	20,1999999999...	NULL
10	1308	Addison	village	IL	17	1700243	35702	6	3570,19999999...	10,0000000000...	NULL
11	3454	Addison	town	TX	48	4801240	16661	6	3821,30000000...	4,36000000000...	NULL
12	188	Adelanto	city	CA	06	0600296	38046	6	719,500000000...	52,8800000000...	NULL
13	1817	Adelphi	Census Designated Place	MD	24	2400400	16823	6	6184,89999999...	2,72000000000...	NULL
14	2019	Adrian	city	MI	26	2600440	20645	6	2530,00000000...	8,16000000000...	NULL
15	2258	Affton	Census Designated Place	MO	29	2900280	20417	6	4467,60000000...	4,57000000000...	NULL

Once you have selected the appropriate attribute field under *Value* (H), you can click *Classify* (I). QGIS then looks up all **unique values** of that field in the attribute table and lists them (K). Each value gets its own symbol, based on the symbol set under *Symbol* and with a colour from the selected *Color ramp* (J), by default random colours. At the bottom of the list QGIS also adds a category *all other values*, for features whose value does not appear in the list (for example values added to the data later).

After generating the categories, you can adjust each symbol individually: colour, shape, size… To do this, double-click the symbol you want to change under K. You can also edit the automatically created **descriptive legend**, which by default contains the name of the field value, by double-clicking the legend text. To delete a category from the list, select it and click the red minus button (I). To hide a category on the map without deleting it, untick the checkbox in front of it.



In some cases you do not want a separate category for every unique value, but only want to highlight a few values. Suppose, for example, that you want to highlight the places with the class `city` and show all other places in the same colour.

1. Choose the field `CLASS` under *Value* (H), as before. Do not click *Classify* this time, but click the green plus symbol (I). QGIS adds a new category to the list (K). Its value is still empty, so QGIS shows it as *all other values*.
2. Double-click the *Value* column of this category and type the value you want to highlight, in this case `city`.
3. Click the green plus symbol again to add a second category, and leave its value as it is (*all other values*). All features with another value, such as `town` or `village`, get the symbol of this category.
4. Give both categories the symbol you want.

Warning

Values must match the attribute table exactly, including upper and lower case: `city` is not the same as `City`.